GQH-01 ORBIT STABLE

← ALL TRACKS

T R A C K 0 2 · Q U A N T I T A T IVE P U Z Z L E S MISSION FILE: MULTIPLANETARY EXCHANGE SYSTEM

INCOMING TRANSMISSION · EARTH GATEWAY · 2126-09-22 00:00 TDB

R E A D T H E C H A L L E N G E

10/2/26, 7:41 PM The MultiPlanetary Exchange | Gator Quant Hacks 2026

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C H 01 T H E C O M M I S S I O N

In this Gator Quant Hacks track, you have 40 hours to design a financial exchange for nine settlements. Explain how people trade, how payments finish and what happens when communication fails. Submit a design paper and an evidence appendix; coding is optional.

01

M I S S I O N F I L E S · R E L E A S E D O C T 2, 2 0 2 6

Participant brief + Alpha orbital data
The brief is the official rulebook. The data pack holds the orbital
elements, network model and JPL source files.

READ THE BRIEF (PDF) ORBITAL DATA (ZIP)

L O G 01
A L L S T A T I O N S

It is 22 September 2126. Humanity lives at nine settlements strung from Mercury to Neptune, and every planet sits exactly where the real one was on 22 September 2026.

L O G 02
E A R T H → M A R S

An investor on Earth wants 100 shares of Ares Habitat from a seller on Mars. The money is on one
planet. The shares are on another.

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L O G 03
C E R E S ⇄ M A R S

A mining crew on Ceres pulls metal out of the asteroid belt. A factory on Mars needs that metal. Both want to lock in a price today on a contract that settles 20 days from now.

L O G 04
N E P T U N E → E A R T H

Out at Neptune, four light-hours from home, a participant wants their savings usable back on Earth.

L O G 05
U N R E S O LV ED

Your task is to design the exchange that handles transactions like these, including what happens when messages arrive late or payments fail.

Y O U R T A S K
40 H O U R S

Write the rules that let people at all nine settlements buy and sell investments, transfer assets and enter financial

contracts. Decide who operates the exchange, how transactions are recorded and how money and shares become available to their new owners.

There is no fixed assignment: you choose your own opening balances and test scenarios. Show each step precisely enough that a reader can follow a transaction from its first instruction to its final outcome, and explain what your rules guarantee, under which conditions and at what cost. The 40 hours is your submission deadline, not the market’s lifetime.

I N S C O PE E Q U I TIE S · F U T U R E S · O PTI O N S · B O NDS ·
C U R R E N C IE S · LE NDI N G · S H O R T S · C LE A R I N G · S ETTLEME N T

K E Y F I N A N C I A L T E R M S

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⇄
MA R KET

Where buyers and sellers find each other and agree on a price.

Prices may have changed by the time a buyer receives a quote from another settlement.

≡

C LE A R I N G

Working out exactly who owes what to whom once a trade is agreed.

Each settlement keeps records, but updates take time to reach the other side.

✓

S ETTLEME N T

Actually moving the money and the shares so the trade is final.

Your rules must make the shares usable on Earth and the payment usable on Mars.

!

MA R G I N & D EF A U LT

Collateral posted up front, plus the rulebook for when someone cannot pay.

A request for more collateral can take hours to arrive or get lost.

T H E B R I E F F I X E S

■ Where every planet and relay is, and how they move

■ The relay network, its 19 links and their limits

■ How messages travel, get lost and are rationed

■ Physical limits and timing rules

■ How you are scored and what evidence you submit

Y O U D E S I G N

Which institutions operate the exchange (at most 12) and where they are

based

▶

▶ Market structure, contract rules, matching and clearing

▶ Margin, valuation and default procedures

▶ Your opening balance sheet: who holds what, and where

▶ Your test scenarios, including the incident that stresses your design

▶ How users at every settlement get access

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 4/21

▶ Exactly what you guarantee, and under which conditions

C H O O S I N G A DE S I G N

You can use one central exchange, several cooperating exchanges or scheduled trading rounds. No structure is preferred. Explain why your choice works, what participants give up and where it could fail.

C H 02 T H E S P E E D L I M I T

Messages travel at the speed of light. Crossing one astronomical unit (AU), roughly the Earth–Sun distance, takes 8.317 minutes. Your exchange must work while participants wait for instructions and replies. Select a settlement below to compare travel times.

02

T R A N S M I T F R O M
MERCURY VENUS EARTH MARS CERES JUPITER SATURN URANUS NEPTUNE

L I G H T H A S T R A V E L L E D F O R

T+ 02:51:06

PLAYBACK ×1,027 · ↻ REPLAY

Earth 1 h 10 min RECEIVED
Venus 1 h 13 min RECEIVED
Ceres 1 h 14 min RECEIVED
Mars 1 h 15 min RECEIVED
Mercury 1 h 21 min RECEIVED
Jupiter 1 h 48 min RECEIVED
Uranus 2 h 09 min RECEIVED

0m 30m 1h 1.5h 2h 2.5h

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From Saturn on 22 September 2126, the farthest settlement is Neptune, 2 h 51 min away at light speed. A question and its answer take twice that.

Neptune 2 h 51 min RECEIVED

I N F O R M A T I O N A R R IVE S L A T E

Every clock in the system agrees, but no clock can tell you what is
happening on Neptune right now. You only ever see what was true when the
light left.

01

R E P L I E S T A K E T I M E

Getting an answer requires a message in each direction. Near the starting date, an Earth–Neptune round trip takes about eight hours before
processing or retries.

02

T H E M A P M OVE S

Everything orbits, so every distance changes every hour. No distance
table or contact schedule is supplied. You compute them.

03

C H 03 T H E N E T W O R K

Each settlement has one gateway: its connection to the network. Two relays, A
and B, orbit the Sun at about 2.83 AU. You must use this fixed network.
Messages travel in packets of up to 1,024 bytes, with different rules for
exchange coordination and client communication.

03

TX A RX

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BACKBONE For exchange coordination

WHO Exchange operators and their clearing and settlement services
PATH Gateway → relay(s) → gateway. At most 3 links, pinned for the session
LOSS p = 1 − e^(−0.02·d) per launch, d in AU
SAFETY NET Hop receipts, up to 4 launches per hop, endpoint retries
BUDGET 600 new packets per rolling 24 h, for the entire solar system
MUST CARRY Anything that creates a shared exchange record or settlement
authority

DIRECT For client messages

WHO Anyone
PATH A straight line, settlement to settlement
LOSS p = 1 − e^(−0.08·d) per launch, d in AU; higher loss than the

backbone

SAFETY NET No automatic receipt or retry. A reply is a separate message
BUDGET 12 packets per rolling 24 h per principal, at least 60 s apart
FOR Client orders, instructions and observations only

TX RX

P A C K E T L O S S L A B

P A T H L E N G T H d = 1.73 AU (14.3 light-min)

FROM EARTH AT T=0 → VENUS · 0.4 AU MARS · 1.7 AU JUPITER · 6.0 AU
URANUS · 19.0 AU NEPTUNE · 28.9 AU

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 7/21

B A C K B O N E · P E R L A U N C H 4 7 1 / 4 8 3 A R R I V E D

p = 1 − e = 3.4%

Each hop retries until a receipt comes back, up to 4 launches. If those launches were independent, all four would fail with probability p⁴ = 0.0001%.

DI R E C T · P E R P A C K E T 4 3 3 / 4 8 3 A R R I V E D

p = 1 − e = 12.9%

SEND − 1 + COPY

No receipts, no retries. With 1 independent copy, at least one arrives with probability 1 − p = 87.1%, and every copy spends quota.

C A T C H Multiplying probabilities only works when the copies are truly
independent. Copies that share a Sun closure, a forced-loss window or a
queue fail together, and the brief marks down math that pretends
otherwise.

− 0.02 × 1.73

− 0.08 × 1.73

R E M E M B E R

A delivery receipt confirms that a message arrived, not that a trade was accepted. Your exchange rules must define acceptance and final settlement separately.

C H 04 T H E M O V I N G M A P 04

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 8/21

The simulation starts with planetary positions from 22 September 2026 and advances them along fixed elliptical orbits. A route can become unavailable when the Sun blocks it. Use the supplied orbital data to calculate distances and availability; explore the model below to see how they change.

G U IDED T O U R EQUITY · EARTH ⇄ MARS FUTURES · CERES → MARS

TRANSFER · NEPTUNE → EARTH SUN BLOCK · MERCURY ✕ URANUS CONJUNCTION · DAY 545

+100 YEARS

❚❚ 1 HR/S 1 DAY/S 1 WK/S 1 MO/S 1 YR/S EPOCH 200-YEAR VALIDATION SPAN +200 YR

T=0 +1 YR +10 YR +100 YR

R O U T E P L A N N E R
F R O M

Earth ⇄

T O

Mars

M O D E L D A T E

2128-03-16
T+ 541.1 d FROM EPOCH

COMPRESSED TRUE · INNER TRUE · FULL

3D TILT ALL LINKS

YOUR ROUTE DIRECT PATH OPEN LINK SUN-BLOCKED MAINTENANCE

B A C K B O N E O P E R A T O R S O N L Y

10/2/26, 7:41 PM The MultiPlanetary Exchange | Gator Quant Hacks 2026

https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 9/21

EARTH
IN THE STORY · INVESTORS

In the story, investors here buy Ares Habitat shares from Mars. Which of your accounts sit here is up to your balance sheet.
FROM SUN 0.99 AU ORBIT 365 DAYS SEMI-MAJOR AXIS 1.00 AU

SEND FROM HERE SEND TO HERE

F R E E F L I G H T Pick any two settlements. The planner solves the light-time equation with moving receivers, checks every hop against the 0.10
AU solar exclusion and the maintenance windows, and picks the
fastest open backbone route of at most three links.

Positions propagate the brief's frozen JPL elements as fixed Kepler ellipses from 2026-09-22 00:00 TDB (labelled 2126 in the story). Link colours on the map use instantaneous geometry; the planner numbers include light-time, 1 s serialization per launch and 1 s relay processing. A teaching model, not the reference propagator.

EARTH → R-A → MARS
ONE-WAY 50.6 min
HOP LOSS 3.8% · 8.0% ALL HOPS, 1ST TRY 88.6%

OPEN · RECEIPTS + UP TO 4 LAUNCHES PER HOP

ALL 4 CANDIDATE ROUTES (≤ 3 LINKS)

D I R E C T C L I E N T S O N L Y
ONE-WAY 19.9 min
LOSS 17.4%
SUN CLEARANCE 0.021 AU

BLOCKED · PATH CROSSES 0.10 AU OF THE SUN

C H 05 Y O U R S C E N A R I O S 05

10/2/26, 7:41 PM The MultiPlanetary Exchange | Gator Quant Hacks 2026

https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 10/21

There is no fixed assignment. You declare the money and shares that exist, who holds them and where, then run your design through scenarios you choose. Money is counted in NeoDollars ($), an abstract unit that no bank issues and nobody can create more of. The limits below keep the pool closed and let judges compare teams.

Y O U R O P E N I N G B A L A N C E S H E E T E X A M P L E · T H E A C C O U N T S F R O M T H E S T O R Y

N E O D O L L A R S $220,000 OF $500,000 MAX

UNUSED · UP TO $280,000 MORE

A R E S H A B I T A T S H A R E S 1,200 OF 5,000 MAX

UNUSED · UP TO 3,800 MORE

5 A C C O U N T S

4 – 1 0 A LL OWE D

4 S ETTLEME N T S

3 O R MO R E

$0 I N EVE R Y I N S TI T U TI O N Y O U C H A R TE R
F U N D E D O N LY BY R E C O R D E D T R A N S A C TI O N S

INVESTOR · EARTH

$100,000

MINING …

$50,00

MANUFAC…

$50,00

SAVE…

$20,

SHARE SELLER · MA…

1,000

SAVE…

200

An asset supports only one use at a time. Assets held as collateral are not available to spend.
No new money. Every guarantee, credit advance, insurance payout and unit of collateral comes from your opening balance sheet by an explicit transaction.
A loan or a new currency creates matching claims and liabilities, never free
backing.

C H O O S E I T T O F I ND W E A K N E S S E S

This sheet fits the limits, but yours does not have to look like it. Putting accounts far apart, or holdings where they are hardest to use, is how you find where your design breaks. Accounts are fixed for the whole run, and you may not invent extra identities to gain message quota.

Y O U R S C E N A R I O S M U S T C O V E R

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 11/21

COVER 01 FAR-APART ACCOUNTS

MOVE VALUE

E.G. NEPTUNE → EARTH

A trade, a transfer or both, where the receiver can use the result only after two settlements agree. Put the accounts far apart.

D O N E W H E N

Your authoritative record shows it final, each party can spend the result at its
own settlement, and the matching debits are recorded.

COVER 02 OPEN ≥ 240 h

STAY OPEN

PAYMENT MATURITY FUNDED DEFAULT

A contract that stays open for at least 240 hours and ends by payment, maturity or a funded default.

D O N E W H E N

Every obligation ends in a stated state: paid, matured, in funded default, or
still open with a named, funded owner.

COVER 03 RISING AND FALLING RUNS

PAY ON LATER PRICES

▲ RISING ▼ FALLING ≥ 20% MOVE

At least one product whose payments depend on prices observed after it opens, such as a future, an option or a short. The contract names which observations count: the final price, an average, a barrier or another rule.

D O N E W H E N

Two separate runs on price paths you choose, each moving at least 20% from the opening price at some point, under one margin rule.

COVER 04 FROM THE SCOPE LIST

10/2/26, 7:41 PM The MultiPlanetary Exchange | Gator Quant Hacks 2026

https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 12/21

TWO KINDS OF PRODUCT

EQUITIES FUTURES OPTIONS BONDS CURRENCIES LENDING SHORTS

Show at least two different kinds of product from the scope list, for example a share trade and a futures contract.

D O N E W H E N

For each product: quantity, unit, location, maturity, pricing inputs and
valuation source, who bears losses, and what happens at end of life.

H OW T O R U N Y O U R S C E N A R I O S

Every scenario starts from your full opening balance sheet at hour 0 and ends when you say. One run can cover several requirements, or you can run them separately with a declared reset; the rising and falling runs must be separate. Before hour 0 you may only set up sessions, from hour −168 at the earliest. There are no deadlines to hit: you report your own completion times, each with its probability.

M A K E T H E M H U R T

25%

S C A L E

In at least one scenario, a quarter of your opening NeoDollars is encumbered by open positions at the same moment.

MAX LOSS

E X P O S U R E

For every scenario, report each side's largest possible loss and how much of your capital is encumbered.

BIND

A R E A L C O N S T R A I N T

Show one variation of size or price path that forces a margin call, a default or a suspension. If nothing binds, show why not.

10/2/26, 7:41 PM The MultiPlanetary Exchange | Gator Quant Hacks 2026

https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 13/21

WO R K E D E X A M P L E · P A Y I N G O N L A T E R P R I C E S

Take the brief’s example: a cash-settled future on 10 contracts, multiplier 100, entry price 100, paying on the final price P. The long side receives 10 × 100 × (P − 100) NeoDollars in total and the short side pays it. You design interim marking, but interim and final payments together must add up to that total, counted once.

You run it twice from a fresh start, rising and falling, with one margin rule stated before either path is traced. It may use contract terms, observations already received, positions and risk assumptions you declare; never future prices, which run it is, or who will end up paying. Until the first observation after the contract opens, both runs must act the same wherever local information matches.

If a product needs an outside price, name the source, the one settlement where it releases each signed observation, and how often. There is no free broadcast: you decide who carries it onward, when, by which route and on whose quota. Marks, margin calls and settlement instructions between exchanges must use the backbone.

▲ RISING RUN ▼ FALLING RUN E X A M P L E P A T H S · S A M E M A R G I N R U L E I N B O T H R U N S

70

80

90

100

110

120

130

h0 h240 h480 · EXPIRY

ENTRY $100

P = 100

P = 120

P = 125

CERES · SHORT

$25,000
NEODOLLARS

MARS · LONG

$75,000
NEODOLLARS $5,000 →

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 14/21

HOUR PRICE MARK TOTAL TO LONG

0 100 — $0

240 120 +$20,000 +$20,000

480 125 +$5,000 +$25,000

10 × 100 × (125 − 100) = +$25,000
to the long side over the whole contract

A S E A T F O R E V E R Y O N E

Every settlement must support local participation, including at least one
product whose payment depends on later prices. You may restrict products or
risk with good reason, but not by locking a settlement out, dropping price-dependent products or halting service forever. Show it by re-running from reset with one of your accounts moved to another settlement, never by adding capital.

C H 06 W H E N T H I N G S B R E A K

Every run already includes the two scheduled maintenance windows. For the S2 stress run you add one incident of your own on a scenario with a price-dependent product: a 72-hour gateway isolation, a 6-hour forced-loss window or an endpoint reset. Incidents are never announced; participants learn of one only from what fails to arrive.

06

Y O U R S 2 I N C I D E N T · P I C K O N E K I N D 6 H FORCED LOSS 72 H ISOLATION ENDPOINT RESET

MAINTENANCE

YOUR INCIDENT · S2

EXAMPLE FUTURES

B ↔ NEPTUNE

SETTLE · YOU REPORT WHEN

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 15/21

EXAMPLE PRICES

HOUR 240

DAY 10.0

DRAG ACROSS THE TIMELINE · ← → KEYS · INCIDENT PLACEMENTS ARE EXAMPLES

100 120 / 80 125 / 75

h0 h240
DAY 0

h240
DAY 10

h480
DAY 20

h720
DAY 30

Second observation: $120 in the rising run, $80 in the falling run. Each path must move at least 20% at some point.
Scheduled: Relay B to Ceres down in both directions. In the example, this begins as the second price is published at Ceres.
Example contract open: both sides' margin encumbered and the position recorded at
the clearing ledger. Marks and margin calls between exchanges ride the backbone. Example pick: every launch on a link touching Relay A fails for six hours. With
Relay B to Ceres already in maintenance, Ceres has no working backbone link as the second price lands.

P I C K T H E WO R S T M O M E N T

Choose the kind, the node and the start time that hurt your design most, and say why. In this example, hour 240 is when the second price lands at Ceres just as Relay B’s Ceres link enters maintenance. Report how long service was lost, the state of every obligation during the incident, which assets cover them, and the recovery: financial service resumed, not just a packet received.

P L A N F O R C O N T I N U I N G O P E R A T I O N

B L A C K O U T S

A route can vanish for weeks. What
happens to open obligations
meanwhile, and how does service
restart?

B A C K L O G S

When a route reopens, queued work lands all at once. Each link carries one packet per second; queues hold 10,000.

L A T E M A T U R I T I E S

Some obligations mature long after your longest worked example. Your rules still have to handle them.

E X P I R E D P A C K E T S

A packet dies 30 days after it is created. The obligation it was carrying does not.

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 16/21

Every outstanding obligation needs a responsible party and committed funding until your rules resolve it.

Random packet loss prevents an unconditional delivery deadline. For each completion time that depends on direct messages, calculate the probability of finishing by that time and explain what happens if the messages do not
arrive.

C H 07 T H E D E L I V E R A B L E

Within 40 hours of the start: two documents of up to 12 pages each. Code is optional. Calculations, spreadsheets, worked timelines and clearly written procedures can all earn full credit.

07

DESIGN PAPER

Explain your architecture, operating rulebook, supported products, responsibilities, guarantees and their conditions, risks and limits. Include
a service table: for each product and settlement, what is offered, under what conditions and with what restrictions. Cover continuing operation and estimate at least two real-world effects omitted from the model, with sources and assumptions. Keep exact procedures separate from future work. The 12-page limit includes diagrams and references.

There is no live Q&A. Say what every actor knows, does and owes when a message is lost, late, duplicated or contradicted.

12 PAGES

EVIDENCE APPENDIX

SCENARIO TRACES STRESS & RECOVERY

12 PAGES

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 17/21

S1 A no-loss trace at the epoch for
each of your scenarios, with
maintenance and geometry applied, covering the value move, the long-lived obligation and both price
runs. Report completion times, all communications, peak encumbered assets, asset-hours, exposure and capital use, plus the variation that makes a constraint bind.

S2 Add the incident you chose to a
scenario with a price-dependent product. Report lost service, the state of every obligation and the recovery. Repeat without scheduled maintenance and compare, then run
one design change or sensitivity check.

S3 ACCESS EVERYWHERE
Best route, one-way delay and availability from all nine
settlements, at hour 0 and again at hour 300. Then full value-move timelines for a comparable funded client at your best, median and
worst settlement.

E1 ORBITS
Reproduce the epoch positions,
solve light-time, and show receiver motion changing an arrival time.

E2 PROBABILITY & TRAFFIC
Every direct-service success-by-deadline probability, backbone hop-abandonment odds, every packet
counted, both quotas and link
capacity checked.

E3 BALANCES & CAPITAL
Who holds what, where, encumbered
by what, over time, for every scenario. Prove funding is
conserved and nothing is used
twice.

E4 LONG-HORIZON SCAN
Scan at least 200 Julian years of
link geometry and argue what your
step size could have missed. Higher tiers refine an event boundary,
then give availability and delay
ranges for every settlement.

E5 LATER STARTING DATES
Rerun at +1, +10 and +100 years
with orbits advanced and balances
reset. Higher tiers add a difficult
epoch you choose, then both price
directions there.

H O W I T I S S C O R E D · 1 0 0 P O I N T S

30 C O R R E C T N E S S & A S S E T P R O T E C T I O N

Precise, consistent financial state and guarantees that actually hold. Top marks state authority, states, obligations and recovery exactly.

25 E C O N O M I C U S E F U L N E S S

Access and completion time 10 · communication efficiency 5 · capital efficiency 5 · recovery 5. Speed is weighed against guarantees and completion probability, and the rising and falling runs count equally.

10/2/26, 7:41 PM The MultiPlanetary Exchange | Gator Quant Hacks 2026

https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 18/21

20 R I S K D I S C OVE R Y & R E S P O N S E

Identify weaknesses in your design, rank their importance and explain how you address them, including risks created by the way your rules interact. Judges also weigh how hard your own scenarios and incident push on the design.

15 Q U A N T I T A T IVE EVI D E N C E

Three points each for E1 to E5: correct, reproducible calculations with sensitivity analysis. A missing item scores zero.

10 C L A R I T Y & R E P R O D U C I B I L I T Y

A reader can trace every decisive claim from the documents alone, with
proof, assumption and limitation kept apart.

0 P T S T H I N G S T H A T E A R N N O T H I N G

✕ Presentation polish

✕ Code volume

"Blockchain", "consensus", "auction" or "clearinghouse" without a procedure behind the word

✕

✕ A list of product names with no framework or demonstration behind it

✕ Lower capital that comes from unfunded exposure

✕ Extra E4 or E5 runs beyond the tier you claim

WH E R E T O S T A R T

Read the participant brief, especially the fixed parameters in Section 2
and the clarifications in Section 11. Use the supplied orbital data and reference propagator to check the starting positions.

1

Publish your opening balance sheet: 4 to 10 accounts at 3 or more
settlements, within $500,000 and 5,000 shares. Put accounts where they are hardest to serve.

2

Choose where institutions and account records are based. Specify who can approve trades, move assets and resolve failed payments.

3

Trace a value move one step per row: time, actor, local knowledge, action, packet, arrival and financial state after.

4

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https://www.gqhacks.com/tracks/quant-puzzles 19/21

Anyone may enter, subject to the hackathon-wide rules. You can support your design with calculations, spreadsheets, worked timelines or code. Judges must be able to check every key claim from the two submitted documents alone.

State one margin rule, run both price paths, then pick the incident that hurts most and test later starting dates. Record your calculations for the evidence appendix.

5

E N D O F B R I E F I N G

Join the Quantitative Puzzles track at Gator Quant Hacks, October 2–
4, 2026.

APPLY NOW → READ THE BRIEF (PDF)

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This page is a plain-language tour of the MultiPlanetary Exchange System participant brief. Where anything here differs from the brief or a posted clarification, those govern.

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